

Acknowledging the problem

Self-harm is an unhealthy coping mechanism that can be difficult to admit to other people. It often remains a secret because the person who is self-harming fears the reactions of others. Challenging stigma, and being open and nonjudgmental about self-harm in general, will make it more likely for a person who self-harms to seek support.

TEEN HINTS

Getting help

- Talk to someone you can trust, or, if you prefer to talk to someone you don't know, call a support helpline.
- Sometimes it's easier to talk when you're both doing something else, such as cooking a meal or driving. Writing a list or letter in advance can help you tell them exactly what you need them to know.
- Think about what you want to happen next and what support you need.
- Consider seeking professional help, such as from a doctor or school counselor.

PARENT TIPS

Supporting your teen

- Be aware of the behavioral signs, such as becoming isolated or withdrawn, changes in eating habits and weight, depression, drinking or drug-taking, low self-esteem, or wearing long clothing or refusing to wear a swimsuit or sports uniform, in order to hide any injuries.
- Self-harm is typically carried out secretly, so any physical signs might not be obvious. Look for bald patches, bruises, burns, and cuts.
- Encourage your teen to talk, and listen calmly without passing judgment. Agree together what will happen next.
- Seek professional help if you feel you don't know what to do.

Other ways of coping

Understanding what triggers self-harm can help when trying to find an alternative coping strategy—hitting a pillow really hard might help to vent anger, or doing a breathing exercise can help restore a sense of control.

▽ Finding distractions

If talking to a safe person isn't an immediate option, there are all sorts of alternative strategies to help teens cope with overwhelming feelings.



△ Squeeze an ice cube until it melts.



△ Draw and paint on the skin.



△ Flick a hair band on the wrist.



△ Take a cold shower.



△ Play sports or do some exercise.



△ Play relaxing music.



△ Scream loudly.



△ Write down feelings, then scribble them out.